

# MOUTH/THROAT SYMPTOMS

## Give urgent attention to the patient with mouth/throat symptoms and any of:

- Red swelling blocking airway
- Unable to open mouth
- Unable to swallow at all
- If sudden face/tongue swelling and any of: wheeze, difficulty breathing, BP < 90/60, dizziness/collapse, abdominal pain, vomiting or exposure to possible allergen<sup>1</sup>, check for anaphylaxis → 20.

Refer urgently.

## Approach to the patient with mouth/throat symptoms not needing urgent attention

- If on abacavir, check for abacavir hypersensitivity reaction (AHR) → 116. If swelling of lips → 32. If gum or tooth problem → 36.
- Ask about dry mouth and swallowing problems. If food/liquid gets stuck with swallowing, refer.
- Wear a mask while examining the mouth and throat. Check for redness, white patches, blisters, ulcers or cracks:

| Sore/red throat                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | White patches on cheeks, gums, tongue, palate.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Painful blisters on lips/mouth                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | Painful ulcer/s with central white patch                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | Red, cracked corners of mouth                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | Dry mouth                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
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| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Consider for COVID-19 → 40 if not already done.</li> <li>• Examine the patient's throat. Does patient have either of: <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Enlarged tonsils with pus/white patches on tonsils or</li> <li>- Enlarged tonsils <i>without</i> cough or runny nose</li> </ul> </li> </ul> | <p><b>Oral candida</b> likely</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Give <b>nystatin suspension</b> 100 000IU/mL (1mL) 6 hourly after meal for 7 days. Keep inside mouth for as long as possible. Continue for 2 days after white patches resolved.</li> <li>• If on inhaled corticosteroids, advise to rinse mouth with water after use.</li> <li>• Test for HIV → 110 and diabetes → 17.</li> <li>• If patient has a life-limiting illness, also consider giving palliative care → 170.</li> </ul>                                                    | <p><b>Herpes simplex</b> likely</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Test for HIV → 110.</li> <li>• Advise to rinse mouth with salt water<sup>2</sup> for one minute twice a day.</li> <li>• Apply petroleum jelly to blisters on lips.</li> <li>• For pain, give <b>paracetamol</b> 1g 6 hourly as needed for up to 5 days.</li> <li>• If extensive, apply <b>tetracaine 0.5%</b> gel to blisters 6 hourly.</li> <li>• If HIV, give <b>aciclovir</b> 400mg 8 hourly for 7 days.</li> <li>• If severe or no better after 1 week of treatment, refer.</li> </ul> | <p><b>Aphthous ulcer/s</b> likely</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Apply <b>tetracaine 0.5%</b> gel on ulcers 6 hourly.</li> <li>• Refer if: <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Ulcer &gt; 1cm</li> <li>- Not healed within 10 days</li> </ul> </li> </ul> | <p><b>Angular cheilitis/stomatitis</b> likely</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Apply <b>zinc and castor oil ointment</b> 8 hourly.</li> <li>• If patient also has oral candida, treat as in adjacent column and apply <b>clotrimazole cream</b> 12 hourly for 2 weeks.</li> <li>• If crusts and blisters around mouth, <b>impetigo</b> likely → 78.</li> <li>• If very itchy, <b>contact dermatitis</b> likely. Identify and remove irritant.</li> <li>• If dentures, ensure good fit and advise to clean every night.</li> <li>• If on inhaled corticosteroids, advise to rinse mouth after use.</li> <li>• If no better or uncertain of cause: <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- Check Hb. If &lt; 12g/dL (woman) or &lt; 13g/dL (man), <b>anaemia</b> likely → 27.</li> <li>- Test for HIV → 110 and diabetes → 17.</li> <li>- If still uncertain, refer.</li> </ul> </li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• If thirst, urinary frequency, weight loss, exclude diabetes → 17.</li> <li>• If runny or blocked nose → 34.</li> <li>• Look for and treat oral candida (see adjacent).</li> <li>• Review medication: furosemide, amitriptyline, chlorphenamine, antipsychotics and morphine can cause dry mouth. Discuss with doctor.</li> <li>• Advise to sip fluids frequently. Sucking on oranges, pineapple, lemon or passion fruit may help.</li> <li>• If patient has a life-limiting illness, also consider giving palliative care → 170.</li> </ul> |
| <p>No to both</p> <p><b>Viral pharyngitis</b> likely</p> <p>Explain that antibiotics are not necessary.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | <p>Yes to either</p> <p><b>Bacterial pharyngitis/tonsillitis</b> likely</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• If ≤ 21 years old, give single dose <b>benzathine benzylpenicillin</b> 1.2MU IM<sup>3</sup> or <b>phenoxymethylpenicillin</b><sup>4</sup> 500mg 12 hourly for 10 days. If penicillin allergy<sup>5</sup>, give instead <b>azithromycin</b> 500mg daily for 3 days.</li> <li>• If &gt; 21 years old, advise to return if symptoms persist/worsen: discuss/refer.</li> <li>• If ≥ 6 episodes per year, refer for ENT assessment.</li> </ul> | <p>If difficulty or pain on swallowing, <b>oesophageal candida</b> likely:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Give <b>fluconazole</b> 200mg daily for 14 days.</li> <li>• If HIV positive, start ART → 111.</li> <li>• If no better, refer.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Give <b>paracetamol</b> 1g 4-6 hourly (up to 4g in 24 hours) as needed for up to 5 days.</li> <li>• Advise to gargle with salt water<sup>2</sup> for 1 minute twice a day.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |

Advise the patient with a sore mouth/throat to avoid spicy, hot, sticky, dry or acidic food and to eat soft, moist food. Keep mouth and teeth clean by brushing and rinsing regularly.

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<sup>1</sup>Common allergens include medication, food or insect bite/sting within the past few hours. <sup>2</sup>Add 2.5mL (½ teaspoon) of table salt to 200mL lukewarm water. <sup>3</sup>For benzathine benzylpenicillin 1.2MU injection: dissolve **benzathine benzylpenicillin** 1.2MU in 3.2mL **lidocaine 1%** without epinephrine (adrenaline). <sup>4</sup>If phenoxymethylpenicillin not available, give instead **amoxicillin** 1g 12 hourly for 10 days. <sup>5</sup>History of anaphylaxis, urticaria or angioedema.